The teaching profession under pressure

Seminar: helping teachers stay

Dr Wonyong Park | EDUC1033 Week 9 · Seminar

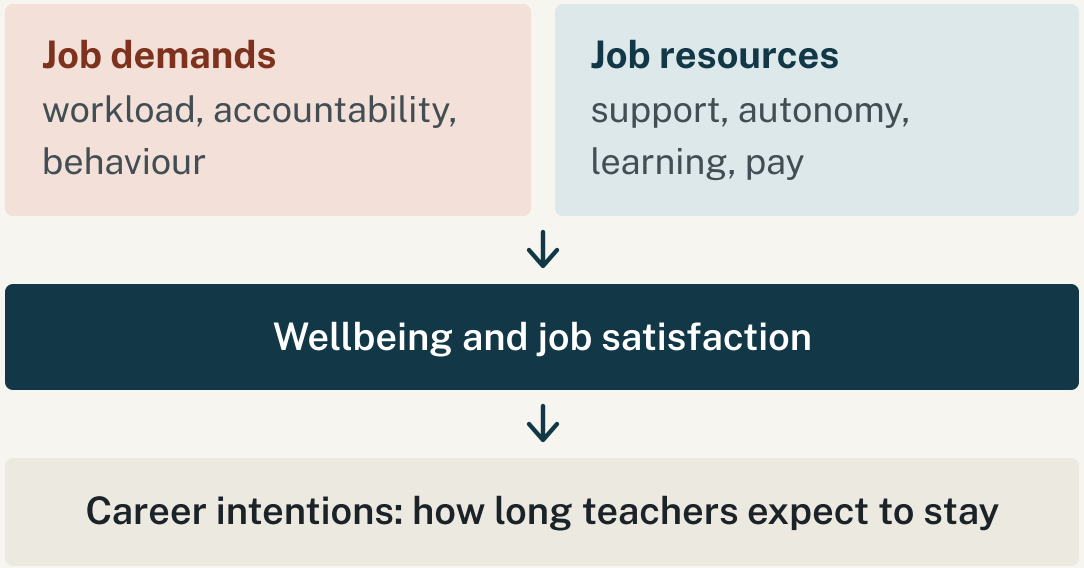


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Recap: what we mean by teacher supply

- **Recruitment:** enough people training and entering posts
- **Retention:** teachers staying in school, sector and occupation
- **Matching:** specialists in the right subjects and places
- **Working conditions:** work that teachers can sustain

Job demands–resources model (OECD)



Report sections 1 and 3; OECD (2025), Figure 1, p. 24.

Recap: recruitment and retention in England

Recruitment, 2025/26

128%	of target for **primary** postgraduate training
89%	of target for **secondary**, up from under half in 2023/24
9 of 18	secondary subjects **below target**, e.g. physics 78%, computing 81%

Retention and the pledge

89.7%	of 2024 qualifiers still in state schools **one year** later
67.4%	of the 2020 cohort still there **five years** later
4,654	additional FTE towards the **6,500 pledge** (June 2026)

Worth & Scott (2026), pp. 10–11; DfE (2026a).

Recap: workload, leaving and pay

Workload

50.1 hours a week in term time for full-time teachers (2025)

Only **26%** of teachers and leaders find their workload acceptable

Why teachers leave

74% of 2025 leavers cite high workload; **73%** stress or poor wellbeing

89% of those considering leaving cite each of these

Pay

Starting salaries are **back to their 2010/11 real level**

Experienced teachers' real pay is **8.6% below** 2010/11

IFF Research & UCL IOE (2025); DfE WLTL Wave 4 (2025); Worth & Scott (2026), pp. 18, 20.

A teacher's account of workload



https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jNUZKdQ1PEQ · BBC Teach, *Confessions of a Teacher: Workload*

Recurring themes in interviews with leavers

- Enjoyment of classroom teaching and relationships with pupils
- Administrative demands and limited support
- Difficulty keeping boundaries around work
- Less autonomy, and a gap between what teachers valued and how the job had developed

60 interviews in autumn 2025 with teachers and leaders who had left or were considering leaving.

IFF Research & UCL IOE (2026), *Qualitative insight into experiences of leavers and those considering leaving*, pp. 5–7. Crown copyright, OGL v3.0.

Activity 1

Small groups | 10 minutes

What did the teacher in the video describe about their workload?

What could be done to help teachers like this stay in teaching?

Priority 1: financial support for entry into training

In place now

- Tax-free training **bursaries of up to £31,000** in the subjects where teachers are most needed
- **Earn while training:** the postgraduate teaching apprenticeship cut to 9 months; a teacher degree apprenticeship pilot in maths
- Help to apply: a "Find a Candidate" service for providers and an advice service for returners

Evidence from this week

- Postgraduate trainees rose **10%** in 2025/26, with STEM trainees up **21%** (computing +44%, physics +36%)
- Secondary still at **89%** of target; business studies (30%) and music (65%) well below
- NFER suggests considering higher bursaries for languages and arts subjects

Does money to start training also help people stay?

DfE (2026b), pp. 4–5, 9–12; Worth & Scott (2026), pp. 4, 10–11.

Priority 2: competitive pay

In place now

- School teacher and leader pay up by **nearly 10%** over two pay rounds
- **Retention payments of up to £6,000** after tax for early career teachers in shortage subjects such as physics and maths, including in FE
- Planned: more pay flexibility for schools, and full maternity pay doubled from 4 to 8 weeks

Evidence from this week

- Starting salaries are back to their 2010/11 real level; experienced teachers are **8.6% below**
- Average UK earnings rose **6.0%** in real terms over the same period
- Pay cited by **25%** of 2025 leavers (39% in 2023) and **49%** of those considering leaving

Who should extra pay go to: new teachers, experienced teachers, or shortage subjects?

DfE (2026b), pp. 8, 14–15; Worth & Scott (2026), p. 18; IFF Research & UCL IOE (2025); DfE WLTL Wave 4 (2025).

Priority 3: protected mentoring and professional learning

In place now

- New teachers get a **two-year induction**; the Early Career Teacher Entitlement started in September 2025
- Reformed **National Professional Qualifications** and new inclusive teaching programmes
- In FE: the Teacher Mentoring Programme and Taking Teaching Further

Evidence from this week

- About **1 in 4** novice teachers across OECD systems has an assigned mentor; **~79%** in Shanghai
- **55%** say professional learning improved their teaching
- Mentoring takes time from experienced colleagues, and meetings can be lost when staff are needed for cover

What would protected time for mentors and new teachers need from a school?

DfE (2026b), pp. 13, 17–18; OECD (2025), pp. 137, 147; report sections 7 and 16.

Priority 4: reduced administration and more flexibility

In place now

- Planning, preparation and assessment time can be done **at home**; a new programme to spread flexible working
- From September 2026, responsibility payments based on responsibility, **fairer to part-time staff**
- Workload tools: Oak National Academy's AI lesson assistant, EdTech testing, a simpler complaints process

Evidence from this week

- Full-time teachers work **50.1 hours** in a term-time week; **26%** find workload acceptable
- **74%** of leavers cite high workload; **42%** cite a lack of flexible working (49% of those considering leaving)
- Leavers describe administrative demands and difficulty keeping boundaries around work

Which tasks could go, and who would pick up the rest?

DfE (2026b), pp. 8, 15–16; IFF Research & UCL IOE (2025; 2026); DfE WLTL Wave 4 (2025).

Activity 2

Small groups | 20 minutes

Choose two of these priorities. For each, discuss:

1. What problem does it address well?
2. What might it miss, or what could go wrong in practice?

- Financial support for entry into training
- Competitive pay
- Protected mentoring and professional learning
- Reduced administration and more flexibility